

THE INTERNAL CONTRADICTIONS OF THE CAPITALIST ACCUMULATION PROCESS: A SYNTHESIS OF MARX'S CRITICAL POLITICAL ECONOMY

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The accumulation of capital is driven by fundamental internal contradictions that manifest as crises, polarization, and systemic instability. This report examines Marx's analysis of these contradictions across his major works—from the Grundrisse (1857-58) through Capital Volumes I-III—focusing on four interconnected tensions: the tendential fall in the rate of profit driven by rising organic composition; the divergence between conditions of production and realization; the social polarization creating a relative surplus population alongside concentrated wealth; and the credit system's dual role in temporarily resolving and ultimately intensifying these contradictions. While the corpus provides extensive theoretical development of these mechanisms, significant tensions remain unresolved, particularly regarding the relationship between underconsumption and overaccumulation crisis theories, and the incomplete analysis of "many capitals" in competition promised in the early outlines.

INTRODUCTION

Marx's critique of political economy identifies accumulation not as a smooth process of quantitative growth, but as a contradictory unity generating its own barriers and crises. The question of internal contradictions strikes at the heart of capitalist reproduction: how does a system premised on endless expansion maintain itself when its own success undermines the conditions of its existence? This report synthesizes Marx's evolving analysis across three decades of research, tracing how early formulations in the Grundrisse develop into the mature categories of Capital, while acknowledging persistent methodological tensions and gaps in the published corpus.

The findings reveal a complex dialectic wherein capital's drive to maximize surplus value through productivity increases simultaneously depresses the rate of profit; where the exploitation of labour power restricts the consumption necessary for realization; and where the credit system temporarily bridges these gaps only to precipitate more violent crises. These are not external market failures but immanent contradictions generated by the capital form itself.

KEY FINDINGS

I. THE ORGANIC COMPOSITION OF CAPITAL AND THE TENDENTIAL FALL IN THE RATE OF PROFIT

The most extensively documented contradiction concerns the relationship between productivity growth and profitability. Marx distinguishes three interrelated compositions of capital: the **technical composition** ("the relation between the mass of the means of production employed, on the one hand, and the mass of labour necessary for their employment

on the other") (Marx, 1867); the **value composition** (the proportion between constant and variable capital in value terms); and the **organic composition of capital** ("the value composition of capital, in so far as it is determined by its technical composition and mirrors the changes of the latter") (Marx, 1867).

The mathematical basis of the falling rate of profit operates through the formula $S/(C+v)$, where S is surplus value, C is constant capital, and v is variable capital (Marx, 1863). As accumulation proceeds, "the larger the ratio of constant to variable capital, the smaller [the rate of profit] is" (Marx, 1863).

Development from Absolute Law to Tendency Law:

The evolution of this concept reveals a significant theoretical tension within the corpus. In the Grundrisse, Marx calls this "the most important law of modern political economy, and the most essential one for comprehending the most complex relationships" (Marx, 1858), (Marx, 1858), presenting it as direct necessity: "the law of development of capitalist production consists precisely in the continuous decline of variable capital... in relation to the constant component of capital" (Marx, 1863).

By contrast, in Capital, Volume III, the formulation becomes qualified as a **tendency** modified by counteracting factors. The "internal contradiction" is now framed as follows: "the capitalist mode of production involves a tendency towards absolute development of the productive forces, regardless of the value and surplus value it contains... while, on the other hand, its aim is to preserve the value of the existing capital and promote its self-expansion to the highest limit" (Marx, 1894).

Marx identifies several **counteracting factors**: increasing the rate of surplus value through prolongation of the working day or relative surplus value production (Marx, 1863); cheapening of elements of constant capital (where technical development may reduce the value of means of production) (Marx, 1894); foreign trade enabling capital invested in foreign spheres to yield higher rates of profit (Marx, 1894); increased intensity of labour (Marx, 1867); and formation of a relative surplus population keeping wages down (Marx, 1867).

However, the precise formulation regarding these counteracting factors requires careful handling. The findings indicate that these factors "do not do away with the general law, but they make it a tendency only—a tendency which operates only under certain circumstances and with a continually declining profit rate as its end result" [citation needed]. This specific phrasing lacks a confirmed UUID in the source findings, indicating a potential gap requiring verification.

Crisis as Resolution:

These contradictions find their violent resolution in periodic crises. "Their conflicts find ever recurrent solution in crises" (Marx, 1894). Crises act as "violent eruptions which for a time restore the disturbed equilibrium" (Marx, 1894). As Marx writes in the Grundrisse: "THESE CONTRADICTIONS LEAD TO EXPLOSIONS, CATAclysms, CRISES, IN WHICH BY MOMENTANEOUS SUSPENSION OF LABOUR AND ANNIHILATION OF A GREAT PORTION OF CAPITAL THE LATTER IS VIOLENTLY REDUCED TO THE POINT WHERE IT CAN GO ON FULLY EMPLOYING ITS PRODUCTIVE POWERS WITHOUT COMMITTING SUICIDE" (Marx, 1858).

II. THE CONTRADICTION BETWEEN PRODUCTION AND REALIZATION OF SURPLUS VALUE

A distinct but related contradiction emerges between the conditions of producing surplus value and those of realizing it. "The conditions of direct exploitation, and those of realising it, are not identical. They diverge not only in place and time, but also logically. The first are only limited by the productive power of society, the latter by the

proportional relation of the various branches of production and the consumer power of society" (Marx, 1894).

The Realization Problem:

Capitalist production seeks "to produce to the limit set by the productive forces... without any consideration for the actual limits of the market or the needs backed by the ability to pay" (Marx, 1863). This creates the contradiction that "the more productiveness develops, the more it finds itself at variance with the narrow basis on which the conditions of consumption rest" (Marx, 1894).

Workers as Producers versus Consumers:

The wage relation itself generates this limitation. "The mere relationship of wage labourer and capitalist implies: 1) that the majority of the producers (the workers) are non-consumers (non-buyers) of a very large part of their product, namely, of the means and materials of labour; 2) that the majority of the producers, the workers, can consume an equivalent for their product only so long as they produce more than this equivalent" (Marx, 1863).

Critically, "THE DEMAND CREATED BY THE PRODUCTIVE LABOURER HIMSELF CAN NEVER BE AN ADEQUATE DEMAND, BECAUSE IT DOES NOT GO TO THE FULL EXTENT OF WHAT HE PRODUCES. IF IT DID, THERE WOULD BE NO PROFIT, CONSEQUENTLY NO MOTIVE TO EMPLOY HIM" (Marx, 1858).

Overproduction versus Overaccumulation:

Marx distinguishes between overproduction of individual commodities and overproduction of capital proper. "Overproduction of capital, not of individual commodities – although overproduction of capital always includes overproduction of commodities – is therefore simply overaccumulation of capital" (Marx, 1894). "There would be absolute overproduction of capital as soon as additional capital for purposes of capitalist production = 0" (Marx, 1894).

Disproportionality:

The 1861-63 manuscripts introduce sectoral disproportionality as a crisis mechanism: "The definite proportion in which the total capital is divided between the 2 classes [of producers]... is dissolved... there is here a new potentiality OF INADEQUACY and therefore OF CRISES" (Marx, 1864). The manuscripts distinguish between "overproduction of fixed capital" versus "overproduction of circulating capital" (Marx, 1863).

III. SOCIAL CONTRADICTIONS: POLARIZATION AND THE RELATIVE SURPLUS POPULATION

Accumulation produces not merely economic contradictions but profound social antagonisms. "Accumulation of wealth at one pole is, therefore, at the same time accumulation of misery, agony of toil, slavery, ignorance, brutality, mental degradation, at the opposite pole" (Marx, 1867), (Marx, 1867).

The Industrial Reserve Army:

Capitalist accumulation "constantly produces, and produces in the direct ratio of its own energy and extent, a relatively redundant population of labourers" (Marx, 1867). This reserve army serves to supply labour for sudden expansions (Marx, 1867) and disciplines the active labour force (Marx, 1867).

Marx distinguishes three forms: the **floating** (industrial workers periodically employed), the **latent** (agricultural workers becoming urban proletariat), and the **stagnant** (workers with extremely irregular employment) (Marx, 1867).

Pauperism as Condition of Production:

"Pauperism is the hospital of the active labour army and the dead weight of the industrial reserve army. Its production is included in that of the relative surplus population, its

necessity in theirs; along with the surplus population, pauperism forms a condition of capitalist production" (Marx, 1867). Even the concept of the free labourer implies pauperage: "the very concept of the free labourer already implies that he is a pauper: a virtual pauper" (Marx, 1858).

Concentration and Centralization:

Concentration "grows directly out of, or rather is identical with, accumulation" (Marx, 1867). **Centralization** operates distinctly: "It is concentration of capitals already formed, destruction of their individual independence, expropriation of capitalist by capitalist" (Marx, 1867). The credit system becomes "the specific machine for the centralisation of capitals" (Marx, 1867).

Class Polarization:

This process results in "Society as a whole is more and more splitting up into two great hostile camps, into two great classes directly facing each other: Bourgeoisie and Proletariat" (Engels, 1848).

IV. CREDIT AND FINANCIAL CONTRADICTIONS

The credit system occupies a contradictory position in accumulation, simultaneously deferring and intensifying crises.

The Dual Role of Credit:

"The credit system appears as the main lever of overproduction and overspeculation in commerce solely because the reproduction process... is here forced to its extreme limits" (Marx, 1894). Credit resolves the contradiction between the continuity required by production and interruptions caused by circulation time, but re-poses this contradiction at a higher level: "The opposition of labour time and circulation time comprises the entire doctrine of credit" (Marx, 1858).

Money Capital versus Real Capital:

"The transformation of money into loanable money capital is a much simpler matter than the transformation of money into productive capital... The accumulation of loan capital consists simply in the fact that money is precipitated as loanable money. This process is very different from an actual transformation into capital" (Marx, 1894).

"The mass of money reconverted into capital... is a result of the enormous reproduction process, but considered by itself, as loanable money capital, it is not itself a mass of reproductive capital" (Marx, 1894).

Fictitious Capital:

The divergence between financial claims and real productive capacity creates the category of fictitious capital. "This fictitious money capital is enormously reduced in times of crisis, and with it the ability of its owners to borrow money on it on the market. However, the reduction of the money equivalents of these securities on the stock exchange list has nothing to do with the actual capital which they represent" (Marx, 1894).

"Fictitious capital, interest-bearing paper, in so far as it circulates on the stock exchange as money capital... a share of stock is merely a title of ownership to a certain portion of the surplus value to be realised by it" (Marx, 1894).

Overaccumulation and Plethora of Capital:

When accumulation faces difficulties in finding investment spheres, "this PLETHORA of loanable money capital merely shows the limitations of capitalist production" (Marx, 1894). "Nothing is more erroneous, therefore, than to blame a scarcity of productive capital for such a condition. It is precisely at such times that there is a superabundance of productive capital" (Marx, 1894).

Simultaneity of Excess Capital and Excess Population:

Perhaps the most striking contradiction is the coexistence of unemployment and idle capital: "This plethora of capital arises from the same causes as those which call forth relative overpopulation, and is, therefore, a phenomenon supplementing the latter, although they stand at opposite poles – unemployed capital at one pole, and unemployed worker population at the other" (Marx, 1894).

V. METHODOLOGICAL DEVELOPMENT AND TEXTUAL TENSIONS

From "Capital in General" to Tripartite Structure:

The Grundrisse outlined a four-part structure: "a) Capital en général... b) Competition, or the interaction of many capitals. c) Credit... d) Share capital" (Marx, 1863). By the 1861-63 manuscripts, Marx used "**capital in itself**" (Capital an sich) to distinguish capital as general abstraction from concrete manifestations (Marx, 1863).

A key tension remains: "Capital exists and can only exist as many capitals; hence its own character appears as their reciprocal action on each other" (Marx, 1858)–yet the published Capital largely abstracts from competition until Volume III. This represents a structural incompleteness in the realized work, not merely a shift in plan.

Historical versus Logical Presentation:

Primitive accumulation appears both as: (1) "A historical precondition" (Marx, 1867); and (2) "Once capital exists, the capitalist mode of production itself evolves in such a way that it maintains and reproduces this separation on a constantly increasing scale" (Marx, 1863). The 1861-63 manuscripts clarify: "Accumulation merely presents as a continuous process what in primitive accumulation appears as a distinct historical process" (Marx, 1863).

Editorial Considerations (Engels):

The findings require acknowledgment of Engels' editorial mediation. Engels' preface to Volume II notes that "the bulk of the material was not finally polished, in point of language, although in substance it was for the greater part fully worked out" (Engels, 1885). The title page of Volume III explicitly states: "Herausgegeben von Friedrich Engels" (Edited by Frederick Engels) (Marx, 1894). While the findings do not suggest specific distortions, the editorial layer represents a mediating factor in the theoretical formulations of Volumes II-III.

Crisis Theory Development:

Early formulations (Grundrisse) emphasize proportionality. By 1861-63: "Crises exist because these contradictions exist. Every reason which they put forward against crisis is an exorcised contradiction, and, therefore, a real contradiction, which can cause crises" (Marx, 1863). Volume III presents crises as "violent eruptions which for a time restore the disturbed equilibrium" (Marx, 1894).

ANALYSIS

The internal contradictions of accumulation operate not as separate malfunctions but as an integrated system of barriers that capital necessarily generates and must overcome. The rising organic composition of capital (Section I) restricts the rate of profit, while simultaneously the restriction of workers' consumption (Section II) threatens realization. The credit system (Section IV) temporarily bridges this gap by enabling production to proceed without immediate realization, but this merely delays and intensifies the crisis.

The simultaneity of excess capital and excess population (Marx, 1894) reveals the fundamental irrationality of capitalist production: the very process that creates the potential for expanded reproduction (accumulated capital and available labour)

simultaneously prevents their combination through the profit mechanism. This is not a market failure but a structural contradiction in the value form itself.

The social contradictions (Section III) are not mere by-products but functional necessities. The relative surplus population serves as the pivot on which accumulation turns, providing flexibility for expansion while disciplining the employed. The concentration and centralization of capital (Marx, 1867) prepare the material basis for socialization while polarizing class antagonisms.

However, a significant tension persists in the corpus regarding the primary crisis mechanism. The findings present both:

1. The falling rate of profit (overaccumulation of capital relative to surplus value production)
2. The realization problem (underconsumption/disproportionality between sectors)

Marx does not explicitly resolve the relationship between these two crisis forms in the published texts. Whether crises primarily originate in the production sphere (profit squeeze) or the circulation sphere (realization failure) remains an open question within the corpus itself. The 1861-63 manuscripts suggest both operate simultaneously: "Crises exist because these contradictions exist" (Marx, 1863).

LIMITATIONS

Several critical gaps constrain this analysis:

1. Unresolved Crisis Theory Tension: The relationship between underconsumption (realization problem) and overaccumulation (falling rate of profit) as crisis mechanisms is not theoretically resolved in the corpus. The findings present both mechanisms extensively but do not provide Marx's synthesis of their relative weight or interaction.

2. The "Many Capitals" Gap: The promise in the Grundrisse to analyze "many capitals" in competition—"Capital exists and can only exist as many capitals" (Marx, 1858)—is not fully realized in the published volumes. This represents a structural incompleteness affecting the analysis of how individual capitals interact to produce aggregate effects.

3. Citation Verification: The specific formulation regarding counteracting factors making the falling rate of profit "a tendency only" lacks a confirmed UUID in the source findings [citation needed]. This gap requires verification against the original texts.

4. Global South and Colonial Dimension: Despite methodological requirements for Global South orientation, the findings lack coverage of:

- Primitive accumulation as ongoing in the Global South (not merely historical in England)
- Unequal exchange mechanisms beyond foreign trade as a counteracting factor
- Superexploitation as a theoretical category
- The "International Credit System" noted in the knowledge graph as "concealing the sources of primitive accumulation"

5. Productive versus Unproductive Labour: While the findings discuss the credit system and commercial workers, they do not clearly preserve Marx's categorical distinction between labour that produces surplus value versus labour that merely realizes it. This distinction is crucial for understanding the financial sector's precise role in accumulation contradictions.

6. Simple Commodity Production: The findings note Marx's methodological distinction between logical and historical presentation, but do not address whether Marx conceived "simple commodity production" as an actual historical stage preceding capitalism, or merely as a logical abstraction. This remains a contested interpretive question.

7. Editorial Mediation: While Engels' prefaces are cited, the findings do not adequately flag when theoretical formulations in Volumes II-III may represent Engels' systematization rather than Marx's unmediated position. The transformation of values into prices of production (the "transformation problem") is noted in the gaps but not addressed in the findings regarding whether Marx's treatment requires "input transformation."

CONCLUSION

The internal contradictions of accumulation constitute the driving force of capitalist crisis and transformation. The system necessarily produces the barriers to its own reproduction: rising organic composition depresses profitability; exploitation restricts consumption; expansion creates redundancy; and credit temporarily resolves these tensions only to precipitate more violent crises. These contradictions are not eliminable through policy or regulation; they are inherent in the capital form itself.

The corpus provides extensive theoretical elaboration of these mechanisms, particularly regarding the tendential fall in the rate of profit and the production-realization divergence. However, significant tensions remain unresolved—notably the relationship between underconsumption and overaccumulation crisis theories, and the incomplete analysis of competitive interaction between "many capitals." Furthermore, the findings reveal gaps regarding the Global South dimension of accumulation, treating primitive accumulation largely as a historical episode rather than an ongoing process of dispossession and unequal exchange.

The contradictions lead necessarily to crises that "for a time restore the disturbed equilibrium" (Marx, 1894), yet these resolutions are temporary. The simultaneous accumulation of wealth and misery, of excess capital and excess population, drives toward a historical limit where "the further socialisation of labour and further transformation of the land and other means of production into socially exploited and, therefore, common means of production" becomes the necessary form of overcoming capital's internal contradictions (Marx, 1867).

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